Field Notes on Municipal Audit Backlogs

Prepared for the Cedar Hollow Review - fictional working notes, 2026

Why backlogs form

Audit backlogs rarely appear because a review team works slowly. They form when new cases arrive faster than the team can close them for longer than one budget cycle. A delay of two or three weeks in spring becomes a queue of unopened files by autumn.

The queue then changes how the office behaves. Staff close the easy cases first, and the average age of the remaining files quietly rises while managers report throughput instead of backlog age, which hides the problem from the people who fund the team.

The pattern shows up in ordinary intake logs. Intake stays flat while closures fall behind, and the gap between the two curves is the backlog taking shape. Nothing about that gap is mysterious; it is arithmetic.

Three forces push the gap wider. Intake grows with the town, rules change more often than training does, and vacancies stay unfilled until the next budget year.

Measuring the queue

A backlog is best measured by age, not by count. A queue of four hundred files that are ninety days old is a different problem from four hundred files that are nine days old, even though both offices would report the same headline number.

The useful figures are the oldest open case, the share of cases older than one quarter, and the closure rate over the last ninety days. Those three numbers, published monthly, make the queue visible without any new tooling.

Publishing those three numbers changed the conversation. The board stopped asking how busy the team was and started asking which rule change had made the back-
log wider without adding staff.

In the fictional example used throughout these notes, the review office held 1,900 open files at the end of 2024, and 37 percent of them were older than one quarter. The oldest case had waited 214 days.

Clearing older cases

Clearing a backlog is not the same as working faster. The durable approach is to hold a small share of capacity for old cases, month after month, until the tail is gone. Teams that sprint for one quarter usually hand the condition of the queue to the next quarter.

A simple rule works: every week, close the oldest case that can be closed with the evidence already on file. The rule needs no software, and it keeps the tail from growing while the rest of the queue is serviced.

What worked in practice

In the example office, the oldest-case rule removed 90 days from the maximum wait in five months without new staff. The share of cases older than one quarter fell from 37 percent to 11 percent.

These are fictional working notes, but the shape of the result matches what the wider literature reports: backlogs yield to patient, published, age-first rules, and they return the moment attention moves elsewhere.